DESIGN
BUILD
CORPORATION

A HOMEOWNER'S GUIDE

Building your home in 6 simple steps.

What happens, in what order, and what to check, so you can build with confidence.

YOUR ROADMAP

Your house in 6 steps

Every house is built in the same order. Read each step a few weeks before it starts, and use the checklist at the bottom of each page.

1	Plan and get approvals	1–3 months
2	Foundation	3–5 weeks
3	Structure and roof	4–6 months
4	Pipes and wiring	1–2 months
5	Finishing	4–6 months
6	Test and move in	2–4 weeks

12–16 months
Typical total time for a 10-marla, double-storey home.

+10%
Keep this extra in your budget.

STEP 1 OF 6

Plan and get approvals

01

Get the plan and the paperwork right before anyone starts digging.

Time: 1–3 months

01	**Check your plot**	Make sure the corner markers match the plot map.
02	**Test the soil**	This tells the engineer how deep the foundation must go.
03	**Get two sets of drawings**	Architectural drawings for the layout, and structural drawings for the steel and concrete.
04	**Get the plan approved**	From CDA, RDA, DHA, Bahria or your society. Never start without approval.
05	**Apply for utilities**	Apply for electricity, water and gas early, because they take time.
06	**Make a budget**	List every item of work, and keep 10% extra.

CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ Approved plan in hand
- ☐ Contract signed, with payments linked to stages
- ☐ Store and water ready on site

TIP

Before you choose a contractor, visit two houses they have built: one finished and one still under construction.

STEP 2 OF 6

Foundation

02

This is the base of your house. Once it is buried, it can't be fixed cheaply.

Time: 3–5 weeks

01	**Mark the layout**	Measure both diagonals of each room. If they are equal, the corners are square.
02	**Dig**	To the depth on the drawing, usually 4–6 ft for a 1–2 storey home.
03	**Press the base firm**	Brick ballast is laid, watered and compacted.
04	**Treat for termites**	This should be done by a licensed pest-control firm.
05	**Pour the footings**	The steel sits on spacer blocks, and the concrete is shaken with a vibrator.
06	**Seal with DPC**	A damp-proof layer stops moisture rising into the walls.

CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ Engineer checked the steel before the pour
- ☐ Soil filled back in layers, each pressed firm
- ☐ DPC laid

TIP

Never let concrete be poured until your engineer has checked the steel.

STEP 3 OF 6

Structure and roof

03

The columns, walls and roof slabs form the skeleton of your house.

Time: 4–6 months

01	**Build columns and walls**	Use good bricks, soaked in water before laying.
02	**Fix door and window frames**	Order them early. They go in as the walls rise.
03	**Prepare the roof slab**	Shuttering, steel and electrical points all go in before the concrete.
04	**Engineer checks**	Before every roof pour, without exception.
05	**Pour the slab in one go**	Stopping halfway leaves a weak line in the roof.
06	**Keep it wet**	Water the slab for 10–14 days, and leave the supports in for at least 14.

CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ Slab steel checked
- ☐ Fan hooks and wiring pipes placed before the pour
- ☐ Slab watered every day

TIP

Be on site the day the roof is poured. It is the most important day of the build.

STEP 4 OF 6

Pipes and wiring

04

Everything hidden inside your walls goes in now, before they are closed up.

Time: 1–2 months

01	**Wiring pipes**	Give ACs, the kitchen and the geyser their own circuits.
02	**Water pipes**	Pressure-test them before the walls are closed.
03	**Drains**	Lay them on a steady slope, and run water through them to test.
04	**Waterproofing**	Waterproof the roof and bathrooms before any tiles go down.
05	**Plaster**	Work from the top floor down, and keep the plaster wet for a week.

CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ Water pipes tested
- ☐ Roof and bathrooms waterproofed
- ☐ Earthing installed

TIP

Photograph every wall before plaster, with a measuring tape in the shot. That's your map of hidden pipes and wires, forever.

STEP 5 OF 6

Finishing

05

This is what you will see and touch every day.

Time: 4–6 months

01	**Choose early**	Pick tiles, fittings and the kitchen early. Late choices are the biggest cause of delay.
02	**Floors**	Buy 5–10% extra tiles, all from the same batch.
03	**Bathrooms and kitchen**	Decide where every fitting goes before tiling.
04	**Doors and windows**	Hang the doors after the floors are laid.
05	**Paint**	Paint only once the walls are completely dry.
06	**Lights, fans and ACs**	Install these last, once the dusty work is done.

CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ Tiles tapped: no hollow sounds
- ☐ Walls dry before painting
- ☐ Defects list cleared

TIP

Keep a list of every small defect as you go, and get each one fixed before the workers leave.

STEP 6 OF 6

Test and move in

06

Test everything while the contractor is still around to fix it.

Time: 2–4 weeks

01	**Roof**	Fill the roof with water for 72 hours, then check the ceilings below for damp.
02	**Water and drains**	Open every tap and run water through every drain.
03	**Electricity**	Test every switch, socket and breaker.
04	**Gas**	A licensed fitter checks for leaks with soapy water, never a flame.
05	**Water tanks**	Clean them before you use the water.
06	**Paperwork**	Collect the completion certificate and the warranties.

CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ All tests passed
- ☐ Completion certificate applied for
- ☐ Final payment settled

TIP

Then the best part: Quran khwani, a housewarming, and your family's first night home.

PAYING YOUR CONTRACTOR

Pay only for finished work

Money should follow finished, checked work. A schedule like this keeps everyone honest.

01	Contract signed	5%
02	Foundation complete	10%
03	Ground-floor roof poured	15%
04	First-floor roof poured	15%
05	Pipes, wiring and plaster done	15%
06	Finishing complete	30%
07	Tests passed, keys handed over	5%
08	After 6–12 months, if no defects	5%

Never pay ahead of the work.

Check the work on site before every payment.

Agree all changes in writing first.

ON YOUR SITE VISITS

8 warning signs

You don't need to be an engineer to spot these. If you see one, ask about it straight away.

01 **Thin or light steel**
Ask to weigh a sample and check the stamp on the bar.

02 **Fewer cement bags**
Count the bags used against the plan.

03 **Watery concrete**
Good concrete holds its shape. It doesn't flow like soup.

04 **Steel touching the ground**
It needs spacer blocks under it, or it will rust.

05 **Dry roof after a pour**
Nobody is watering it. The slab must stay wet.

06 **Holes in concrete**
Rough, hollow patches mean no vibrator was used.

07 **Cracked or uneven bricks**
Good bricks ring when tapped together.

08 **No pipe testing**
Ask to see the test before walls are closed.

SITE WORDS

Words you'll hear on site

Knowing these makes every conversation with your contractor easier.

Thekedar	Contractor	**Lantar**	Roof slab
Mistri	Mason	**Shuttering**	Mould for concrete
Naksha	Building plan	**Tarai**	Keeping concrete wet
Sariya	Steel bars	**Chaughat**	Door or window frame
Bajri	Crushed stone	**Dhancha**	Grey structure
Rait	Sand	**DPC**	Damp-proof layer

This guide is general information. Your approved drawings, your engineer and local building rules always come first.

PLANNING YOUR HOME?

Build with people who explain every step.

DBCorp designs and builds homes, from the first sketch to moving day.

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